

Hidden worries

What does the May global PMI data tell us?

- ◆ The global composite PMI remained unchanged in May, with both manufacturing and service sector expansion...
- ◆ ...but longer delivery times and frontloading continue to inflate the headline manufacturing index...
- ◆ ...as businesses expect increased price pressures and supply chain problems to persist for now

The global composite PMI in May recorded another month of expansion, at 51.8 – the same as in April. Both manufacturing and services stayed in expansionary territory. Still, the underlying picture isn't especially encouraging.

The global manufacturing PMI came in at 52.6 in May, unchanged from April. The headline is still propped up by longer suppliers' delivery times and frontloading. Firms expect Middle East tensions to disrupt supply chains, pushing prices higher. In the US, both the S&P and ISM manufacturing PMIs showed solid gains in production and rising new orders, largely tied to inventory buildups to hedge against potential shipment delays and cost spikes in coming months. The eurozone, by contrast, is already showing signs of slowing as cost pressures weigh on demand.

The services sector tells a similar story. Higher costs appear to be dampening demand, particularly in the eurozone and the UK. In the US, new orders rose, but firms reduced employment on both measures. Mainland China and India saw activity accelerate on stronger new orders, though price pressures are still a concern.

We don't think the current PMI strength is likely to last, given the challenges of higher inflation. If cost pressures worsen further, demand destruction could follow. In this environment, it's worth leaning more on components like employment, output, and new orders rather than the headline indices.

1. Snapshot of manufacturing and services PMIs

	Manufacturing PMIs			Services PMIs		
	Mar 26	Apr 26	May 26	Mar 26	Apr 26	May 26
World	51.3	52.6	52.6	50.8	51.2	51.3
US	52.3	54.5	55.1	49.8	51.0	50.7
US ISM	52.7	52.7	54.0	54.0	53.6	54.5
Mainland China*	50.8	52.2	51.8	52.1	52.6	54.4
Mainland China NBS	50.4	50.3	50.0	50.1	49.4	50.1
Eurozone	51.6	52.2	51.6	50.2	47.6	47.7
Japan	51.6	55.1	54.5	53.4	51.0	50.0
UK	51.0	53.7	53.9	50.5	52.7	49.3
India	53.9	54.7	55.0	57.5	58.8	59.8
Brazil	49.0	52.6	49.1	50.1	52.3	50.4
Heatmap Key	Below 50 and rising			Above 50 and rising		
	Below 50 and falling			Above 50 and falling		

Source: S&P Global, HSBC. *Refers to RatingDog Mainland China PMI. Due to a later-than-usual release date, May readings for Greece, Indonesia, Ireland, Malaysia, Pakistan, Romania, and Thailand were not available to include in the global calculations.

Economics Global

Maitreyi Das

Global Economist

HSBC Securities and Capital Markets (India) Private Limited

maitreyi.das@hsbc.co.in

+91 80 6737 3155

Bethan Ellis

Global Economist

HSBC Bank plc

bethan.ellis@hsbc.com

+44 20 7991 6714

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Three key takeaways from this month's data

1. Intensifying supply shocks and price pressures are a global theme now

The May PMI releases point to another month of “distorted” growth – headline resilience masking longer delivery times. Quantities of purchases accelerated for a second consecutive month, consistent with firms frontloading inputs amid heightened supply risks linked to the Middle East conflict.

Input costs intensified further in May, with global manufacturing input costs rising at the fastest pace since June 2022. The US recorded the sharpest increase in nearly four years, with respondents pointing to higher costs for petroleum products, steel, and freight. France, Germany, Japan, the UK, and the Philippines also saw faster input price inflation. Yet pass through remains incomplete in many economies, implying renewed margin squeeze rather than a clean shift higher in final-goods pricing. Consequently, orders are being placed to get ahead of increases in output prices. Beyond the Middle East conflict, US tariffs could be another factor in this frontloading. There has been some evidence of US importers bringing forward orders to get ahead of expected increases in tariffs later this year, particularly from Asia.

In the US, both the S&P Global and ISM surveys noted comments pointing to accelerated stockpiling, helping to lift new orders and production to multiyear highs. Japan, India, Korea, and Vietnam also recorded sharp increases in purchasing volumes, reflecting concerns over both supply bottlenecks and rising prices.

2. Regional divergence: US strength vs a fragile eurozone

The US manufacturing upswing looks increasingly entrenched, with production rising to its highest level since April 2022. By contrast, the eurozone is losing momentum. The region's two largest economies – Germany and France – both slowed, with respondents noting that Middle East-related disruptions are weighing on demand via higher costs, and new orders remain muted.

The eurozone headline PMI remained above 50, but the composition warrants caution. Part of the support comes from longer delivery times, which can mechanically lift the index (the logic is that, in a normal situation, longer delivery times indicate higher demand). Removing delivery times from the index would place eurozone manufacturing in contraction. A similar distortion can be seen in the world index, but to a lesser extent.

Elsewhere, in Asia, manufacturing activity improved in economies including India, Korea, and Japan, while they expanded at a slower pace in mainland China. However, the positive impulse appears more risk- than demand-led: a meaningful share of the pickup is consistent with precautionary buying ahead of potential supply chain disruption.

3. Services PMI: Higher costs have started to impact demand

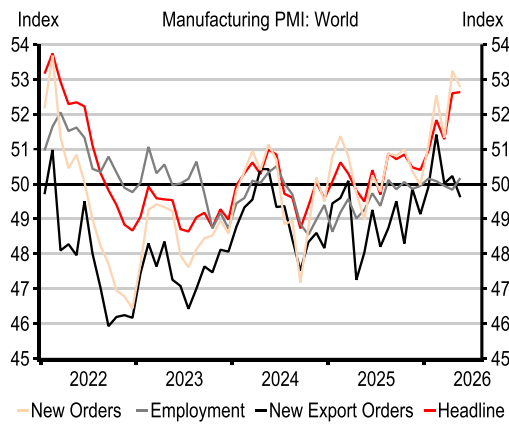
The global services sector continued to expand in May, with the global services PMI at 51.3. New orders expanded, with panellists citing clients frontloading purchases. But employment declined, signalling subdued underlying demand and higher cost pressures. Ultimately, higher price pressures in many economies will weigh on service activity.

The sector is also showing a familiar split. Asia and the US are holding up better than the eurozone and the UK. Stronger new orders – especially in India and mainland China – have driven a faster pace of activity. In the US, the ISM services accelerated, while the S&P index ticked down but stayed in expansionary territory, both supported by new orders. However, employment fell sharply, reflecting some pessimism in the data. In Europe, meanwhile, higher cost pressures have started to curb demand. In the UK, respondents pointed to subdued consumer spending in travel, tourism, and leisure.

A swift de-escalation in the Middle East would ease supply chain constraints and take some heat out of prices, which would help demand. Nonetheless, the conflict has already run for more than three months, and even if the Strait of Hormuz were to reopen, normalisation in PMIs would take time. *See over the page for all the key PMI charts from the latest releases.*

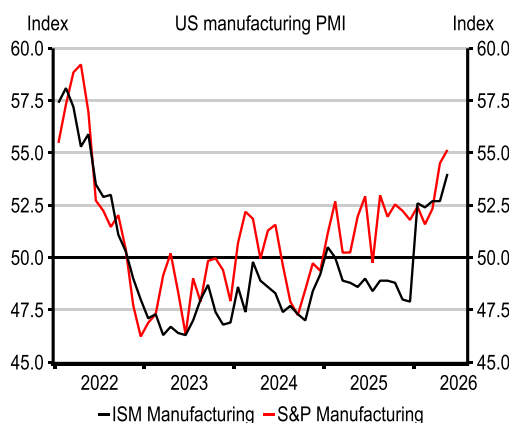
Manufacturing PMIs

2. The global manufacturing PMI came in at 52.6 in May, unchanged from April...



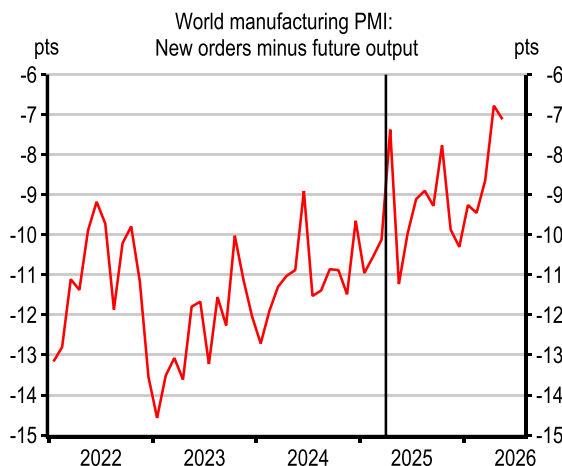
Source: S&P Global, Macrobond. Note: due to a later-than-usual release date, May readings for Greece, Indonesia, Ireland, Malaysia, Pakistan, Romania, and Thailand were not available to include in the global calculations.

4. Manufacturing activity in the US expanded on both measures...



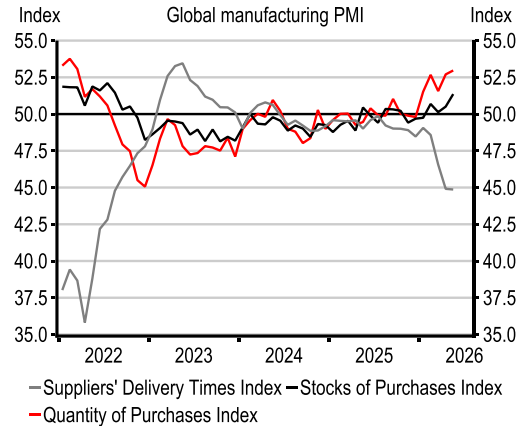
Source: S&P Global, Macrobond.

6. Some of the strength in new orders could reflect frontloading...



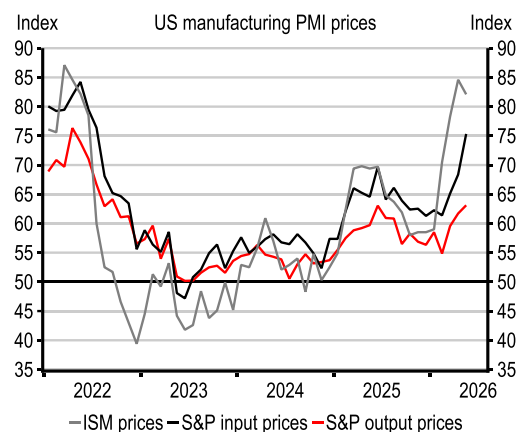
Source: S&P Global, Macrobond. Note: The vertical line reflects the Liberation Day tariff disruption

3. ...although partly due to stockpiling and longer delivery times



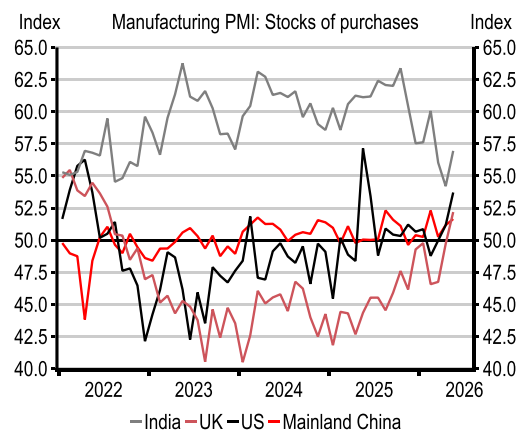
Source: S&P Global, Macrobond. Note: due to a later-than-usual release date, May readings for Greece, Indonesia, Ireland, Malaysia, Pakistan, Romania, and Thailand were not available to include in the global calculations.

5. ...but price pressure remains elevated



Source: S&P Global, Macrobond

7. ...as stocks of purchases increased, indicating inventory buildup



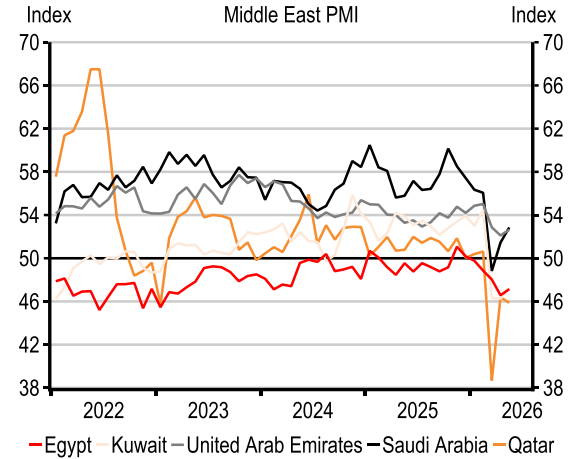
Source: Rating Dog, S&P, Macrobond

8. Manufacturing activity slowed in France and Germany



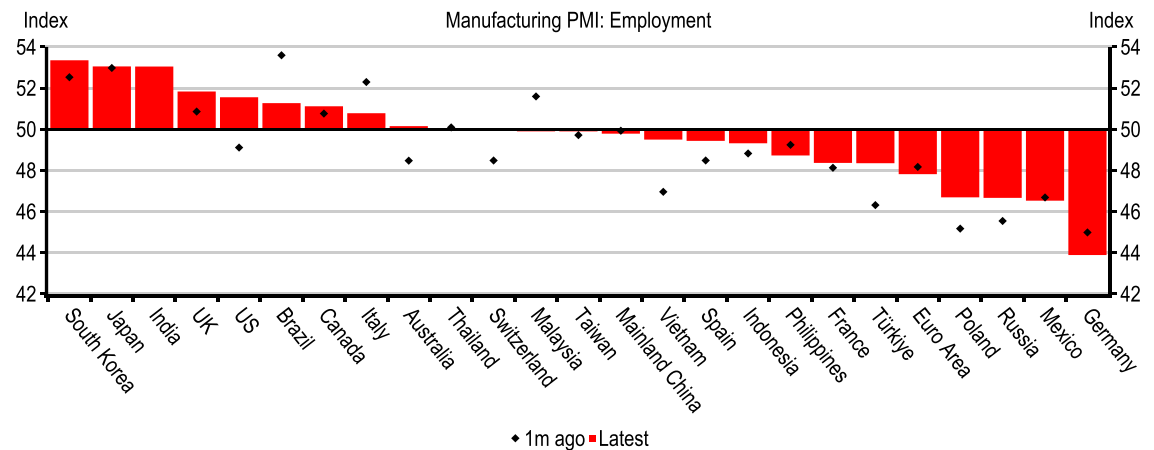
Source: S&P Global, Macrobond.

9. PMIs in the Middle East recovered to some extent in May



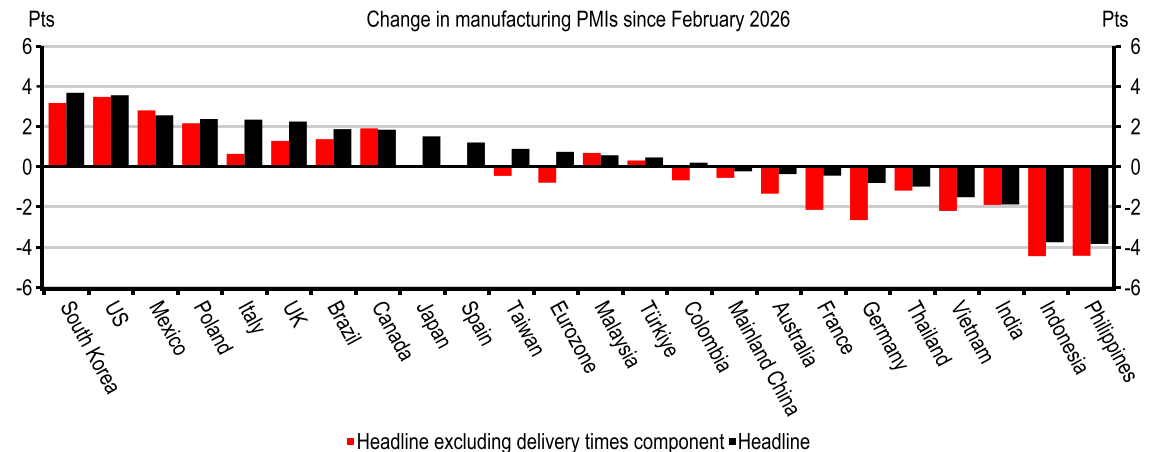
Source: S&P Global, Macrobond. Note: Whole economy PMI

10. Employment data suggest a cautious outlook for the manufacturing sector



Source: S&P Global, Macrobond

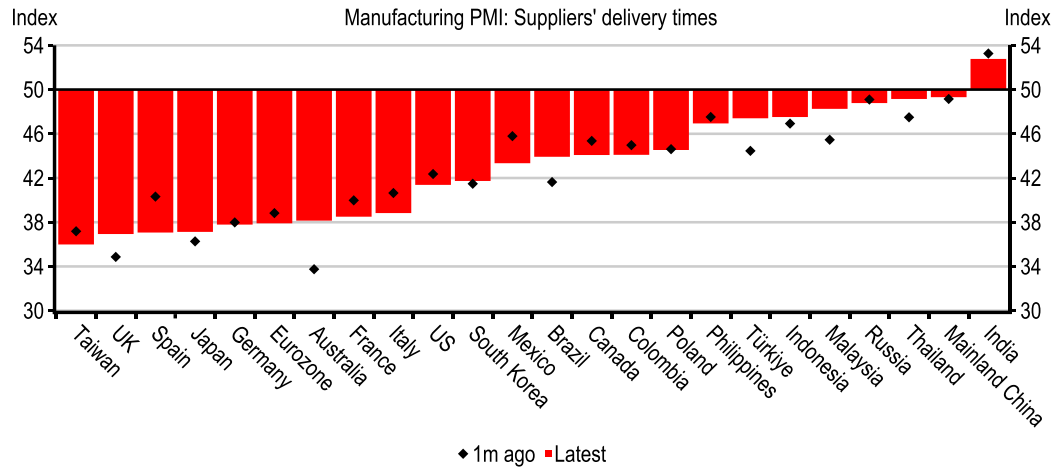
11. Longer supplier delivery times boost the headline data due to methodological quirks



Source: S&P Global, Macrobond, HSBC calculations

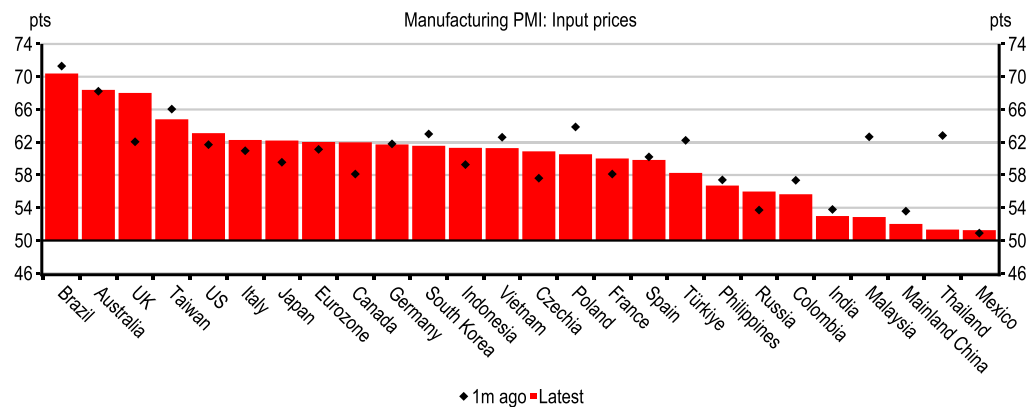
Other key trends in the manufacturing sector

12. Delivery times suggest that supply chain issues may become more challenging in upcoming months



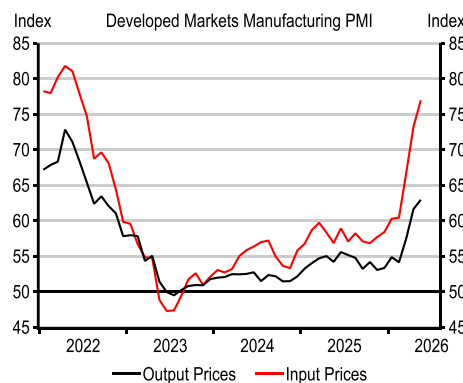
Source: S&P Global, Macrobond

13. Manufacturing input costs remain elevated in most economies, led by higher energy and other commodity prices



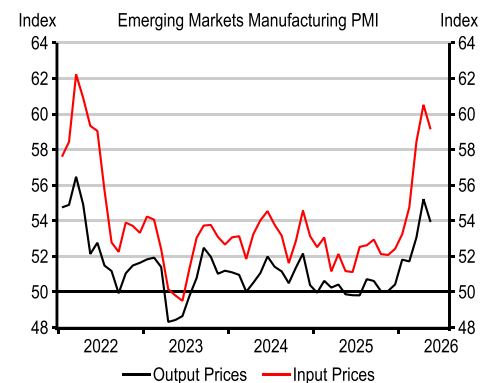
Source: S&P Global, Macrobond.

14. Input and output costs rose in developed markets...



Source: S&P Global, Macrobond

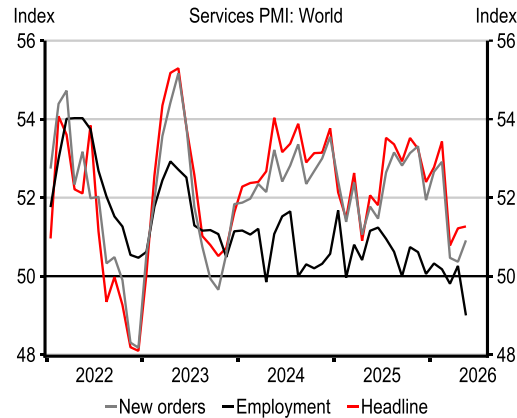
15. ...but increases slowed slightly in emerging markets



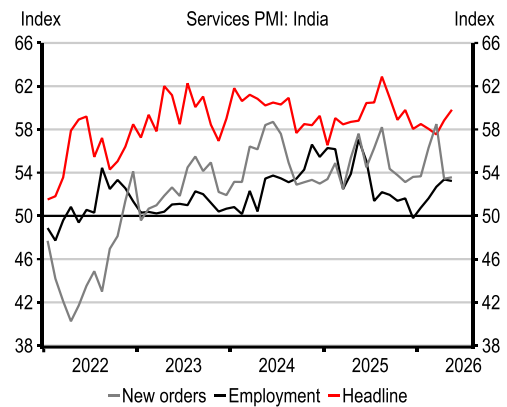
Source: S&P Global, Macrobond

Services PMIs

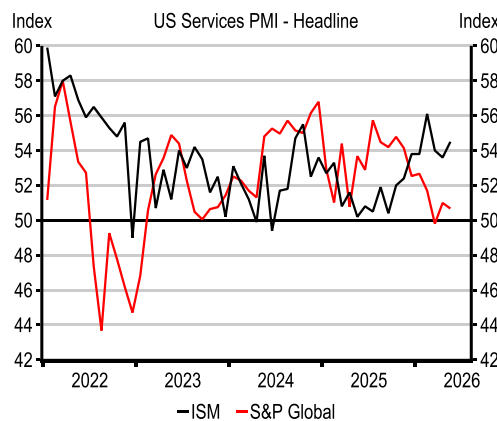
16. The global services PMI expanded marginally in May...



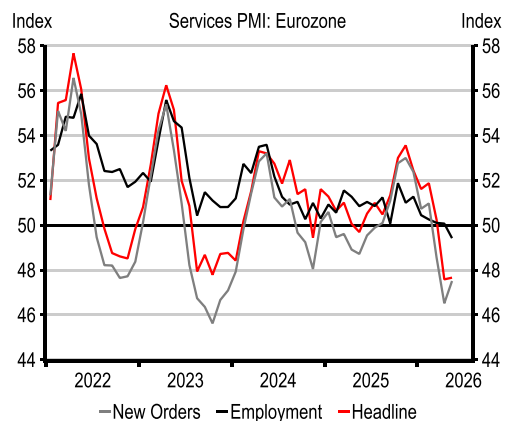
17. ...with India still strong



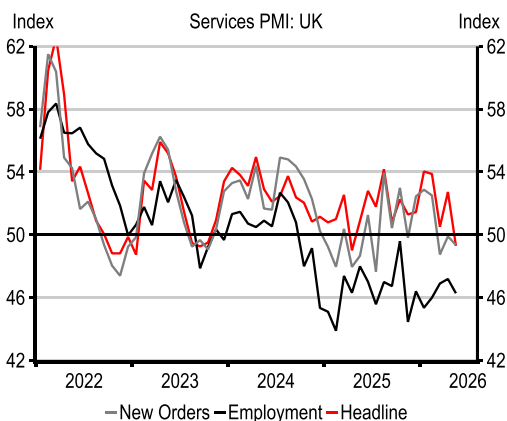
18. The US services PMIs diverged in May, with ISM rising, a payback from April



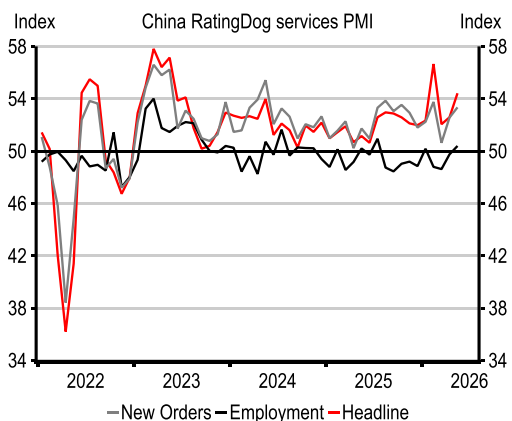
19. The eurozone services PMI slowed, led by Germany and France



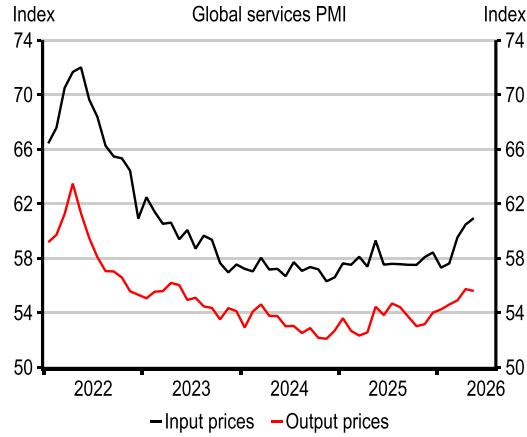
20. The UK services sector also deteriorated in May, as price pressures remain intense...



21. ...and mainland China saw steady growth, but still subdued employment

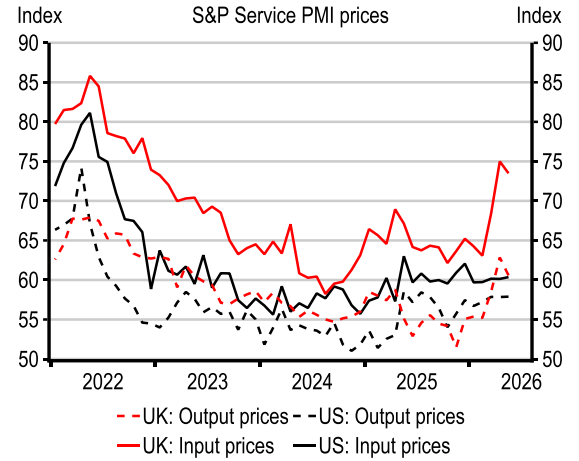


22. Both services input costs and output costs rose further in May...



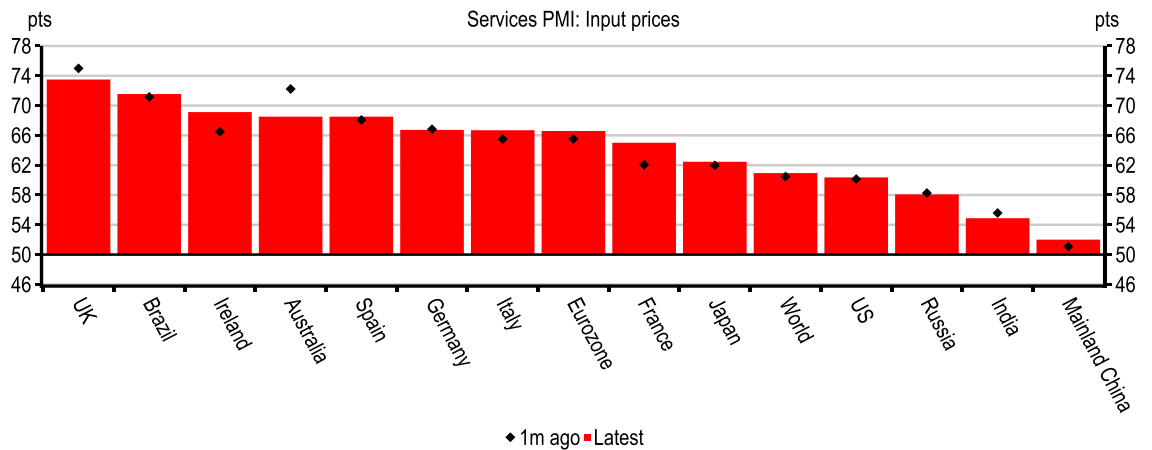
Source: S&P Global, Macrobond

23. ...with input costs notably elevated in the UK...



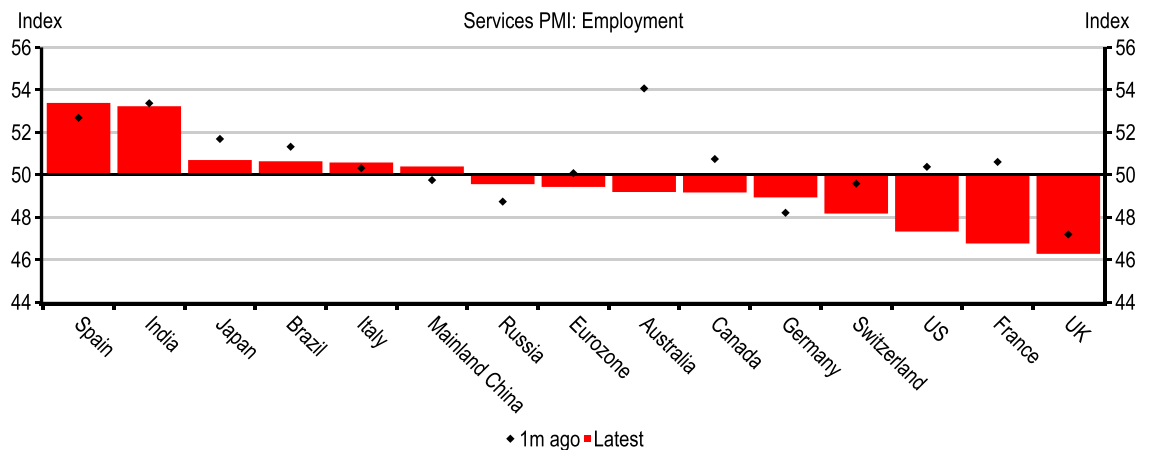
Source: S&P Global, Macrobond

24. ...and are high across most global economies...



Source: S&P Global, Macrobond

25. ...with firms in the US, the UK, France, and Germany reporting cuts to employment



Source: S&P Global, Macrobond

26. Detailed breakdown of manufacturing and services PMIs

	Manufacturing PMIs									Services PMIs		
	Headline			New Orders			Employment			Business Activity		
	Mar 26	Apr 26	May 26	Mar 26	Apr 26	May 26	Mar 26	Apr 26	May 26	Mar 26	Apr 26	May 26
US	52.3	54.5	55.1							49.8	51.0	50.7
US ISM	52.7	52.7	54.0							53.9	55.9	57.7
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Japan	51.6	55.1	54.5							53.4	51.0	50.0
India	53.9	54.7	55.0							57.5	58.8	59.8
Korea	52.6	53.6	54.8							-	-	-
Indonesia	50.1	49.1	50.0							-	-	-
Malaysia	50.7	51.6	49.9							-	-	-
Thailand	54.1	52.7	52.6							-	-	-
Philippines	51.3	48.3	50.8							-	-	-
Vietnam	51.2	50.5	52.8							-	-	-
Eurozone	51.6	52.2	51.6							50.2	47.6	47.7
Germany	52.2	51.4	50.1							50.9	46.9	48.1
France	50.0	52.8	49.7							48.8	46.5	44.3
Italy	51.3	52.1	52.9							48.8	49.8	49.4
Spain	48.7	51.7	51.2							53.3	47.9	50.1
UK	51.0	53.7	53.9							50.5	52.7	49.3
Poland	48.7	48.8	49.4							-	-	-
Russia	48.3	48.1	48.8							49.5	49.7	48.7
South Africa	50.8	51.6	49.6							-	-	-
Brazil	49.0	52.6	49.1							50.1	52.3	50.4
Mexico	48.9	47.7	49.6							-	-	-

Key

Below 50 and falling

Below 50 and rising

Above 50 and falling

Above 50 and rising

Source: S&P Global, HSBC. *Refers to RatingDog Mainland China PMI Note: Due to a later-than-usual release date, May readings for Greece, Indonesia, Ireland, Malaysia, Pakistan, Romania, and Thailand were not available to include in the global calculations.

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Issuer of report

HSBC Securities and Capital Markets (India) Private Limited
Registered Office
52/60 Mahatma Gandhi Road
Fort, Mumbai 400 001, India
Telephone: +91 22 2267 4921
Fax: +91 22 2263 1983
Website: www.research.hsbc.com
SEBI Reg. No. INH000001287
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Global Economics Research Team

Global

Global Chief Economist
Janet Henry +44 20 7991 6711
janet.henry@hsbcib.com

Global Economist
James Pomeroy +44 20 7991 6714
james.pomeroy@hsbc.com

Global Economist
Bethan Ellis +44 20 7991 6714
bethan.ellis@hsbc.com

Trade Economist
Shanella Rajanayagam +44 20 3268 4118
shanella.l.rajanayagam@hsbc.com

Europe

Chief European Economist
Simon Wells +44 20 7991 6718
simon.wells@hsbcib.com

Senior Economist
Chris Hare +44 20 7991 2995
chris.hare@hsbc.com

United Kingdom

Senior Economist, UK
Elizabeth Martins +44 20 7991 2170
liz.martins@hsbc.com

UK Economist
Emma Wilks + 44 20 3268 5948
emma.wilks@hsbc.com

Germany

Stefan Schilbe +49 211 910 3137
stefan.schilbe@hsbc.de

Anja Sabine Heimann +44 738 724 7457
anja.sabine.heimann@hsbc.com

France

Chantana Sam +33 1 4070 7795
chantana.sam@hsbc.fr

North America

US

Ryan Wang +1 212 525 3181
ryan.wang@us.hsbc.com

Asia Pacific

Co-Head of Global Research, Asia-Pacific
and Co-Head of Asian Economics Research
Frederic Neumann +852 2822 4556
fredericneumann@hsbc.com.hk

Chief Economist, Australia, New Zealand and
Global Commodities
Paul Bloxham +612 9255 2635
paulbloxham@hsbc.com.au

Chief Economist, India and Indonesia
Pranjul Bhandari +65 6658 4976
pranjul.bhandari@hsbc.com.sg

Jamie Culling +612 9006 5042
jamie.culling@hsbc.com.au

Jing Liu +852 3941 0063
jing.econ.liu@hsbc.com.hk

Ines Lam +852 2288 7131
ines.y.k.lam@hsbc.com.hk

Yun Liu + 852 2822 4297
yun.liu@hsbc.com.hk

Aayushi Chaudhary +91 22 2268 5543
aayushi.b.chaudhary@hsbc.co.in

Maitreyi Das +91 80 6737 3155
maitreyi.das@hsbc.co.in

Erin Xin +852 2996 6975
erin.y.xin@hsbc.com.hk

Aris Dacanay +852 3945 1247
aris.dacanay@hsbc.com.hk

Jin Choi +852 2996 6597
jin.h.j.choi@hsbc.com.hk

Akiko Kitamura +852 2996 6676
akiko.kitamura@hsbc.com.hk

Justin Feng +852 2288 7108
justin.feng@hsbc.com.hk

Taylor Wang +852 2288 8650
taylor.t.l.wang@hsbc.com.hk

Priya Mehrishi +91 97 3916 9567
priya.mehrishi@hsbc.co.in

CEEMEA

Chief Economist, CEEMEA
Simon Williams +971 50 9143382
simon.williams@hsbc.com

Senior Economist, Central & Eastern
Europe
Agata Urbanska-Giner +44 20 7992 2774
agata.urbanska@hsbcib.com

Senior Economist, CEEMEA
Melis Metiner +44 20 3359 2636
melismetiner@hsbcib.com

Senior Economist, South Africa
Hugo Pienaar +44 20 7718 9563
hugo.pienaar@hsbc.com

Latin America

Chief Economist, Mexico
Jose Carlos Sanchez +52 55 5721 5623
jose.c.sanchez@hsbc.com.mx

Allison Buck +1 212 525 4119
allison.buck@us.hsbc.com

Head of Brazil Economics Research
Daniel Lavarda +55 11 2802 2640
daniel.lavarda@hsbc.com